When the night is darkest, we bring forth the light

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by Lisra

Summary

Catra has lived through many awful things in her short life, but she has survived and now she is fourteen and is awaiting her big moment on this midwinter holiday.

OR

A canon species Scandinavia AU minific. Illustrated.

Notes

This began as a joke during the preparations for a SPOPFlex event but it wouldn't leave my mind. I gift this to my fellow Scandi the_frank in particular and everyone working on the SPOP Icebreaker 'Zine (mark your calendars, coming in January 2026).

Illustrated by luna mikin.

As always many heartfelt thanks to my beta reader Lyssandia!

See the end of the work for more notes

The room is stuffy but it doesn't matter. She knows she must look cute but it doesn't matter. She has been looking forward to this all week but it doesn't matter. All of her thoughts are focused on the single thing, circling it like screaming seagulls.

“Adoraaa!” Catra doesn’t so much howl as mewl. Her tail is a lashing mess under her long robe and her ears are drooping despite her best efforts.

“What?”

Catra hesitates and then plunges forward with honesty.

“I’m scared!”

The change that comes over her friend, girlfriend actually, maybe, certainly, probably, certainly, is immediate. She puts down the large white taper she is fiddling with and turns to face her, her blue eyes open and full of concern. She takes both of Catra’s hands and squeezes them. Catra’s breathing calms down. It’s almost embarrassing how well it works, but Catra is almost over being embarrassed. Almost.

“You’ll be great, Catra. You just have to lead the procession in and look majestic! We’ll do the rest. You don’t even have to sing!”

Thank the heavens for that. Catra might have a good singing voice, but that’s not for all of them outside this stuffy room to know.

“Everyone will be staring at me,” she mumbles, putting her finger on the nub of the problem. Adora musters all the conviction of her fourteen years.

“As they should! You deserve it!”

Catra shakes her head as if that would dislodge the lingering thoughts of inadequacy. Of how absurd the entire situation is.

Adora squeezes her hands again.

“You were hidden for far too long. You deserve to be out in the open and not scared. And I’m right behind you.”

Catra can’t take her eyes off Adora even if she wants to hide right now. She looks, there is no other word for it, saintly, in her white gown and her blonde hair brushed straight - Catra is really proud of her work - and only a slim band of flowers on her head. She is so beautiful now, even though she says she’s *stocky* and *gangly* and that may be so but who *cares*. Catra does not, not remotely. She has only recently adjusted to Adora being in her life again.

“It should have been you,” Catra deflects but Adora shakes her head vigorously.

“It has been me before. This is your honor, we all voted for you.”

Catra feels her lips tremble. Adora steps slowly forward and envelops her in an embrace.

“This moment is for you, Catra. I know it seems silly and pointless and weird, but we all think you’re great and deserve it. I think you’re great. I…” she doesn’t speak more, but squeezes her tighter. Catra makes a deep, rumbling sound of delight and hugs Adora back. She understands. She can’t find words either. So much has happened in such a short time. Maybe this *is* a moment for her that the other kids have given her, whatever the grown-ups think about it. However stupid it seems to outsiders.

A door opens.

“Girls, are you ready?”

Their youth group leader, Mara, and Adora’s second cousin, has finally shown up. Catra can *hear* her smirking but she doesn’t let go. Screw her!

“We are,” Adora answers and, to Catra’s regret, starts to let go.

“What if wax gets in my hair and fur?”

Glimmer pushes past Mara into the room and takes a good look at them. She rolls her eyes, but Catra guesses it’s in affection. Glimmer is her sister now, or so the law says, and that counts for something. Catra has never had a sister before and it’s nice. But sometimes it’s a challenge.

“It’s *fine,* Catra,” Glimmer says and waves her arms around. Her sleeves are a bit too long for her, but she rocks the outfit anyway. She has led the procession twice when she was a child and even from the second or third row she walks and looks like a princess. Her vividly violet hair will surely shine brilliantly in the dim light.

“These candles melt so slowly and if you keep the pace it’s *fine.*”

“Did you drip wax on yourself?” Catra hisses, unwilling to fully let go of Adora.

“Of course not. Now get your butts out there, everyone is waiting!”

The moment has come. Adora steps away from her with a final squeeze of her hands. Mara comes over and gently places the wooden crown on her head. The white candles are straight as arrows - they rest on spikes after all and can’t possibly fall over. But Catra will only relax once it’s all over.

Mara squeezes her shoulder.

“You’ll do great, kit. They’ll follow your lead. Just keep your back straight and relax your shoulders like we practised and stick to the path.”

She lights Adora’s taper first. The blonde girl keeps the candle in both hands, her face a mask of utter concentration. Catra kneels in the way they practised and she feels Mara lighting the candles. Soon Catra’s Crown is, as it were, crowned with flames. Carefully she takes her first steps and then leaves the small room. It leads to a dark corridor where a dozen children and teenagers are

waiting, all wearing the same white robes with green belts instead of the golden one Catra is wearing. The girls are holding tapers and the few boys hold staves with glowing stars affixed to them. Catra walks past them and waits. She can't see it but she knows that Adora lights their candles one by one with her own. Mara opens the door to the outside.

"Showtime," she whispers and everyone choruses the word back to her.

Catra, back straight and chest pushed out, steps forward. Outside the dark of the polar night is almost total. As she steps into the gloom the people shrouded by the dark who have been patiently waiting for them to start singing. Low at first and then rising. Catra takes one step at a time, walking with care and pride. The whole thing is stupid, she said so many times, but it doesn't feel like it now. It is dark, the winter cold bites, and one can feel all life trying to hang on in the cold night. But here she and those behind her come, bringing light into darkness, dispelling the grasp of midwinter as people have done since time immemorial, to keep up joy and hope and the knowledge that spring, light, warmth and life will inevitably return again. She wonders what the real Lucia would say, if she could see this, how people hundreds and hundred of years after her death kept her name if not her memory alive.

Santa Lucia the people, parents, siblings, neighbours, the odd stranger sing. Catra doesn't know anything about her, but she feels anyone would be glad to bring light into darkness. She is, she realizes. Right now, in this strange moment, she is fourteen years old and she has everything. A new family with parents and a sister and friends and neighbours and other magicats and she has Adora, sweet Adora, who is right behind her singing the same words but looking out for her. Adora with the kind face, warm hands and brave heart, who was so full of courage in the courtroom. Catra is fourteen years old and knows she never wants to be apart from her again.

The dark shape of the church looms to their right, but they are not going in. Catra leads them and they form a half circle in front of it with her in the middle as they sing another song. Catra can't sing and keep herself steady, so she just listens and thinks as the words in a language she has only recently rediscovered make her smile and wonder. She mostly wondered how she ever could have ended up here, the leader of a Lucia procession in a small town in Sweden. It had only been a few months since she and her mother had landed in Norway. Catra still had dreams about it, how she had waited for the woman she called *shadow weaver* in the privacy of her own head, to pass the passport check. How the doors had locked and half a dozen policemen had surrounded the booth where the checks were done and a woman had appeared at her side, whispering "*Don't worry, child, you're safe now. We got her."* Someone had noticed. They had waited for her to come back. They had taken her away. Catra was safe now.

And then she had seen Adora in the courtroom, shining like her personal Lucia, recounting all the bad things no thirteen year old should be able to recall. She had never been more moved and as the assembled folk around her start the final song, recounting how beautiful the earth is, Catra feels tears run down her cheeks.

Catra is glad when the last song ends when it does, because the cold is creeping up her legs, leggings and fur notwithstanding, and her neck is starting to strain under the weight of her crown. She lifts her arms in the gesture practised and she leads her glowing entourage out of the cold and away, back where they had come from. She stops at the end of the corridor staring at the wall. She hears the door close and the sound of Mara stepping up behind her is almost lost in the noise that erupts as everyone starts chatting and extinguishing their candles. Catra feels a gentle pressure on her head as her own crown is made safe and then Mara lifts it off her head.

Catra takes a deep breath. She has done it. Nothing bad happened. She led them, she even mouthed along to the songs and it was beautiful and perhaps the first time these folk had ever seen a kitten leading the procession. Catra puts a hand against

the wall to support herself, legs suddenly a bit wobbly. She has *done it*. She smiles, fangs and all. She might be just a little bit *proud*.


LUNA
MIKINA

***

"And how was it?" Adora asks and sits down next to her. Catra has found a spot in the community room away from the center of attention, but of course Adora came straight to her, carrying a plate full of lussekatter and two glasses of christmas lemonade. The room is warm and bright and the music is thankfully very low. Everyone is chatting and eating.

"It was okay," Catra lies and looks away for a second.

"Uh-huh," Adora intones and pokes her with a finger, "so okay that you seem to glow and float a centimeter above the floor?"

Is it Catra or has the noise of the crowd suddenly dropped off *and* increased many times in volume? It's also gotten very warm all of a sudden, because her face feels like it's on fire.

"Something like that," Catra mumbles and grabs a lussekatt. The golden-yellow swirled bun tastes as good as it looks.

"I saw you bea-ming!" Adora says suddenly and grins like a Cheshire Cat herself, "your mom barely needed to lift you up."

Catra blushes but it's hard to be embarrassed with a mouth full of cake.

"I'd lift you up but Glimmer says that's cringe."

"Sparkles is cringe," Catra says between chews, but she doesn't mean it. Just for today her sister is cool. But Adora…

"I could see you, when you fanned out in the courtyard," Catra says after she has finished her bun and drained her glass, "you really looked like a… like a lightbringer, Adora."

Adora puts her own glass down and takes Catra's hand. Catra feels her fur ruffle at the touch, in the best possible way. She just

suppresses a little sound.

“Isn’t lightbringer like… lucifer?”

Catra scowls. But then again, the names…

“Lucifer, Lucia… what’s the difference?”

They grin. Still holding Catra’s hand Adora gets up and then leans down and Catra tilts her head up and they kiss. It’s short, but a promise for more kisses when they aren’t surrounded by so many people anymore.

“You’ve done so well,” Adora whispers, “and you looked beautiful.”

Catra feels herself melting. She wants to push Adora back down and crawl into her lap. She will later today. But for now she gives her a quick peck back.

“And you.”

Someone cheers. It’s probably Glimmer and Catra sticks up a clawed finger in the vague direction to general laughter.

Catra has endured a lot. But the light is returning. She will live.

End Notes

Thank you all for reading. May you have a good holiday season, weather you celebrate or not. If you are confused about what happened, consider reading this. :D But the tldr is, the celebration is a mixup of a Saint's Day (a St. lucy from Sicily) and a Midwinter celebration, where the darkest day and the coming of new light is celebrated.

The fic title is a reference to the lyrics in the lucia song.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!